

Ada Johnson-Kanu

Assistant Professor of Political Science

University of Kentucky · Department of Political Science

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Academic Positions

University of Kentucky, Department of Political Science

Assistant Professor 2022 –

Affiliate faculty: African and African American Studies; Commonwealth Institute for Black Studies; International Studies

Education

University of California, Merced

Ph.D., Political Science 2021

Dissertation: Colonial Legacies in State Building: Bureaucratic Embeddedness, Public Goods Provision, and Public Opinion in Nigeria

Best Dissertation on Race and Ethnic Politics 2022, REP Section, APSA

University of Akron

M.A., Economics 2014

B.A., Economics 2012

Research Fields

Comparative politics, political economy of development, economic history, Africa

Book Project

Sharing the National Cake: Ethnic Representation and Competition in the Nigerian Federal Civil Service

Manuscript in progress

Peer-Reviewed Publications

1. 2024. [de Kadt, Daniel](#), Ada Johnson-Kanu, and [Melissa Sands](#). “State Violence, Party Formation, and Electoral Accountability: The political legacy of the Marikana massacre.” *American Political Science Review* 118(2): 563–583. [Lead article]

Working Papers

7. The Limits of Local Elections Under Subnational Authoritarianism: Evidence From Nigeria (with Nick Cruz). — *Under Review*
6. Fuel Subsidy Removal in Nigeria: Household Welfare and Public Opinion. — *Revise and Resubmit*
5. The Man Leopard Murders and Contemporary Trust in the Nigerian Criminal Justice System (with

Godwin Okore*). — *Under Review*

4. One-Party Legislatures? Partisan Dominance in Nigeria's State Houses of Assembly. — *Under Review*
3. The Governor's Choice? Speaker Selection in Nigerian State Assemblies. — *Reject and Resubmit*
2. Precolonial States and Development: Evidence from Agriculture in Africa (with [Aditya Dasgupta](#)).
1. The Historical Roots of Ethnic Representation in the Civil Service.

Works in Progress

5. The Political Economy of Colonial Treaty-Making: Evidence from British Treaties in West Africa, 1788–1901.
4. Whose Job Is It? Mandate Fit, and the Delegation of Constituency Projects in Nigeria
3. Two Audiences, Many Forms: The Language of British Colonial Treaties in West Africa
2. How Is Power Shared Below the Cabinet? Ethnic and Gender Representation in the Nigerian Federal Civil Service (with Sullivan Edeani*)
1. Precolonial Military Capacity, Colonial Incorporation, and State Violence

Other Publications

1. 2026. Johnson-Kanu, Ada. Book review of *Electoral Commissions and Democratization in Africa: Everyday Production of Democratic Legitimacy* by Nicholas Kerr. ***Africa Spectrum***.
2. 2022. Johnson-Kanu, Ada. "Historical Origins of Ethnic Representation in the Nigerian Bureaucracy." ***Broadstreet*** blog.
3. 2021. Johnson-Kanu, Ada. "Origins and Consequences of Descriptive Representation in the Nigerian Civil Service." ***APSA Comparative Politics Newsletter***, Fall.
4. 2020. Grossman, Shelby, Sean Gallagher, Ada Johnson-Kanu, Nicole Wilson, and David Thiel. "#ZakzakLifeMatters: An Investigation into a Facebook Operation Linked to the Islamic Movement in Nigeria (TAKEDOWN)." ***Stanford Internet Observatory***.

Awards

- 2022 Best Dissertation Award, APSA Race and Ethnic Politics Section
2019 Department Teaching Award, UC Merced

Teaching

University of Kentucky

Introduction to Comparative Politics (UG)	S2024, S2025, F2025, S2026
African Politics (UG)	S2024, S2025
African Politics (G)	S2026
Political Economy (G)	S2023
Comparative Politics Seminar (G)	F2023, F2025

University of California, Merced

Instructor of Record

African Politics (UG)	Su2020
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*Indicates graduate student co-author.

Teaching Assistant

Introduction to Comparative Politics (UG)	F2016
Introduction to International Relations (UG)	S2018, F2020
Introduction to American Politics (UG)	F2019
Statistical Inference (UG)	F2017
Intermediate Macroeconomics, Economics (UG)	Su2017, F2018

Conferences, Workshops, and Invited Talks

American Political Science Association	2020, 2021, 2023, 2025, 2026
Midwest Political Science Association	2019, 2020 [†] , 2023, 2025, 2026
Women in Legislative Studies Conference	2026
Workshop on Comparative Political Regimes	2026
Category, Hierarchy, and Cooperation Workshop, Santa Fe Institute (Invited)	2025
Southern Workshop on Empirical Political Science, SoWEPS (Panel Chair)	2024, 2025
Virtual Historical Political Economy Workshop	2021, 2025
University of Wisconsin–Madison, Comparative Politics/Political Economy Colloquium (Invited)	2023
Kentucky Political Science Association	2023
Summer Institute on Public Sector Organizational Effectiveness	2023
Working Group in African Political Economy, WGAPE	2020, 2021
Minority Politics Online Seminar Series, MPOSS	2021
African Politics Conference Group, APCG, Online Colloquium	2020
University of California Africanists' Workshop	2020
Western Political Science Association	2020 [†]

[†] Accepted; meeting canceled due to COVID-19.

Service to the Discipline

- APSA Annual Conference, African Politics Section Co-Chair 2026
- SoWEPS 8 Co-Convener 2025
- MPSA Annual Conference, Economic Development Section Chair 2025
- ASA Best Paper Published in ASR, Awards Committee 2024
- APSA Mancur Olson Best Dissertation in Political Economy, Awards Committee 2024
- APCG Online Colloquium, Co-Organizer 2023–2026

Reviewer

Africa Spectrum (2×); *African Studies Review*; *American Journal of Political Science*; *American Political Science Review* (4×); *National Science Foundation*; *Political Studies*; *Third World Quarterly*

University Service

Committees

- Department of Political Science Faculty Search Committee 2026–2027
- Department of Political Science Graduate Committee 2023–present
- Chair, Comparative Politics Comprehensive Exam Committee Fall 2023
- Department of Political Science DEI Committee 2022–2023

Organizer

- African Politics Reading/Research Group 2025–present

Advising

• Faith Awah, Dissertation Committee member	2026–present
• Al Amin MD, Dissertation Committee member	2026–present
• Hannah Cake, Dissertation Committee member	2024–present
• Kitae Lee, External examiner	2026
• Benjamin Leo, Dissertation Committee member	2024–2025
• Sullivan Edeani, Subfield advisor	Fall 2025
• Obaloluwa Aka, Subfield advisor	Fall 2023

Field Work, Skills, and Languages

Field work: Nigeria (2019, 2021, 2023)
Technical: Cloud Vision API, Git, Google Earth Engine, L^AT_EX, QGIS, Python, R
Languages: Igbo (native), Hausa (intermediate)